

REPUBLIC OF LEBANON

United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR)

Refugee Healthcare: A Universal Right, but Whose Responsibility?

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A. What does Lebanon want?

- **International Assistance**: More predictable funding for Lebanon's public hospitals, schools, infrastructure and other essential services.
- **Burden-Sharing**: Donor countries and international organizations to share responsibility rather than leaving Lebanon to manage the crisis alone.
- **Refugee Return**: Support for returns that are voluntary, safe, dignified and sustainable.
- **Government Coordination**: Stronger cooperation and information-sharing between UNHCR and Lebanese authorities.
- **Healthcare Access**: Continued humanitarian support for vulnerable refugees while protecting the capacity of public services used by Lebanese citizens.

B. Why does this matter to Lebanon?

It matters to Lebanon because refugee healthcare is not only a humanitarian issue for Lebanon; it is also an economic, social, and national responsibility issue.

- Lebanon's economic crisis makes it difficult to fund healthcare services. When refugees and Lebanese citizens both need medical treatment, limited funding and hospital capacity can make access harder for everyone.
- Lebanon cannot sustainably finance all refugee-related healthcare costs alone. UNHCR and international donors can help fund treatment, medicines, and essential services.
- If healthcare support is inadequate, refugees may struggle to receive treatment, while already-stretched public services can also affect vulnerable Lebanese families. Lebanon wants assistance that supports both communities.
- Lebanon wants other countries and international organizations to contribute resources. Its argument is that hosting refugees should not leave one country carrying a disproportionate share of the financial burden.
- When public services and household finances are under pressure, unmet needs can increase tensions between communities. Supporting healthcare can help reduce those pressures and strengthen social stability.

C. What has Lebanon said or done before?

When discussing Lebanon's previous policies or statements:

- April 2022 — Lebanon said it could no longer bear the burden alone. Lebanon's government said the economic crisis made it increasingly difficult to host large numbers of Syrian refugees. It called for greater international support and emphasized that refugee return should be a solution.
- December 2022 — Return became a stated priority. Prime Minister Najib Mikati said the return of Syrian refugees was a priority and that Lebanon could no longer bear the consequences of hosting them amid its economic crisis.
- May 2024 — A disagreement over refugee protection. Lebanon's Foreign Affairs Ministry objected to a letter from UNHCR concerning measures affecting Syrian refugees. UNHCR subsequently withdrew the letter and reaffirmed its commitment to cooperation with the Lebanese government.

D. The Strongest Evidence

From 1 December 2025, UNHCR stopped providing its regular hospitalization support for refugees in Lebanon because of global funding shortages. This included emergency hospital admissions and childbirth services.

This matters to Lebanon because the funding gap creates a challenge for refugees who need hospital treatment and for a health system already under pressure. The 2026 Lebanon Response Plan also identifies underfunding and strained healthcare infrastructure as major concerns.

E. Potential Allies and Opponents

Potential Allies:

- Jordan
- Türkiye
- European Union
- United States
- United Kingdom
- Qatar

Potential Opponents:

- France
- Sweden
- Germany
- Norway